

Paintings, pigeons and playful inquiry

Our classroom is in the National Gallery of Ireland

What happens if you move your learning into a gallery or museum for an extended period of time?

Inspired by the *My Primary School is at the Museum* programme in the UK, two classes from Catherine McAuley NS in Dublin became the very first 'school in residence' at the National Gallery of Ireland.

For two weeks in February, the children and their teachers spent their school day at the National Gallery and used the collections and gallery spaces as resources for teaching and learning across the entire curriculum.

Week 1: Cross-curricular exploration

During the first week, the children explored the gallery from every possible angle. They were introduced to staff, learning about the work of curators, art handlers, visitor experiences and education.

In a full-day workshop with artist Fergus Byrne, they investigated paint and palette knives and created a large-scale collaborative piece. The students also went 'behind the scenes' and visited the library and archives.

A real highlight for many of the children was holding Jack B Yeats' Olympic medal – the first ever won for Ireland in 1924. Gallery tour guides also discussed key works from the collection and the architecture of the building.

Urban living

Dr Sandra Austin from Marino Institute of Education explored geography and science with the students.

We discussed urban living – what does it mean to live in a city? How do people work and live together? We considered the perspective of the experts in city living – pigeons! We made pigeon companions and brought them with us on a sensory exploration of urban paintings.

What might it sound like, smell like and feel like to be in this place? What would our ideal city contain? We extended our geographical thinking with a session on mapping; reflecting on our experiences in the gallery, choosing our favourite things and deciding how to represent that journey.

Drama techniques

Teacher-led lessons and activities covered discovery and learning in the curriculum areas of literacy, maths, history and drama. For example, students used the European Art collection as the inspiration for direct speech, exploring the endless possibilities of conversations that the characters in the paintings could be engaged in.

They used drama techniques of tableau to further extend their engagement with the content and discussed perceived emotions and feelings.

Personal connections were made with the paintings and students expressed and investigated them with their peers. Mindfulness exercises relating to specific paintings allowed students to further use their imaginations before creative writing and oral storytelling activities.

Exploring history and society

Irish and local history, life, society, work and culture were addressed through the works of artists including Gerard Dillon, Daniel Maclise, Paul Henry, Jack B Yeats and Anne Yeats.

Viewfinders were used to highlight features in the paintings, which were analysed, discussed and sketched by the students. Students also thoroughly enjoyed making their own origami currachs as well as creating their own personal 'Little Green Fields', highlighting meaningful aspects of their school community.

Perimeter and area were explored by measuring paintings with iPads and a handy measuring feature on our website. Patterns and shapes were tallied around the building. Time was also touched on when discussing and calculating dates associated with the works.





Diary entries at the end of each day for a little homework provided an account of day-to-day responses, highlights and also encouraged a bridge between home and the gallery during the week.

Week 2: Sharing learning

At the end of the first week, the children curated a display of all their work. This was open to the public over two 'open studio' weekends and it was viewed by over 2,000 people.

The display provided an opportunity for the children to bring their friends and families to the gallery to share their experiences. Grandparents of one student commented on how they thoroughly enjoyed their tour with their granddaughter, noting that she had grown in confidence and knowledge. A parent revealed it was their first time in the gallery, sharing her delight that her child was such a competent and informative guide.

'School tour'

In the second week, the children invited the rest of their school to the gallery. They led tours of their favourite works and activities in their studio space to share learning from their residency.

They were confident, expressive and knowledgeable. What was most noticeable was their sense of ownership in their National Gallery, and their paintings. The students were so proud to be guiding their peers and teachers. Any nerves were soon replaced with confident presentations and insider knowledge as the students moved through the building with ease and a sense of belonging.



The impact on the students was transformative, with one parent noting that their son has been inspired to consider taking art as a subject in secondary school after the experience.

Teacher reflection – impact and learning

We, as teachers, special needs assistants and staff at the gallery, worked tirelessly to ensure that the children got as much as we could offer them from this unique experience of spending the week using the magnificent space and materials of the gallery as a classroom.

It was obvious that they thoroughly enjoyed being out of the classroom and in such an open, thought provoking, creative, beautiful space.

Students learnt in an integrated and cross-curricular way that utilised the gallery and the artworks to pique interest and engage in an innovative and creative way. The students were involved in directing every aspect of their own learning. Each child's personality was accommodated in selecting personal favourites to present in week two.

What art contributes to life

The importance of what art contributes to life was more significant being in the gallery and making those connections to many aspects of life and the primary school curriculum. It is not as productive in the classroom with a print of any of these pictures.

After this experience, we will approach visits to the gallery differently. We will aim to visit for shorter periods of time, yet go more often. We believe this approach will enable students to engage with and get to know the art better and appreciate the space more.

The gallery website **nationalgallery.ie** is a fantastic resource and has a wealth of ideas and activities. It is a great place for any teacher to start. The gallery is not just the works of art on the wall, it is the space, the atmosphere and the students' personal ownership of the space that makes it such a unique experience.

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